

Program Learning Summaries

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Abstract

Selected coursework from the Bachelor of Arts in Business program strengthened several areas of professional development, including supervision, critical thinking, workplace communication, and human resource management. Each course provided practical knowledge that supports leadership, decision-making, employee development, and organizational effectiveness. These learning experiences also connect to future career goals after military retirement, especially roles involving operations leadership, compliance, program analysis, policy review, and process improvement.

Program Experiences and Career Objectives

My business coursework gave structure to leadership skills I have developed through years of hands-on experience. In my current role, I supervise people, balance requirements, develop personnel, solve problems, and help keep daily operations moving. Those responsibilities are familiar to me, but the coursework helped me explain them through concepts that civilian employers recognize, such as supervision, decision-making, communication, employee development, and organizational performance.

A job interview requires more than saying I have led people or managed programs. I need to show how that experience connects to workplace expectations, business functions, and measurable results. Principles of Supervision, Critical Thinking Strategies for Business Decisions, Effective Business Communication, and Human Resource Management each strengthened a skill set I already use in my current position. They helped me better connect practical experience to the type of work I plan to pursue after military retirement, particularly roles involving operations, compliance, policy review, program analysis, and organizational improvement.

The course sections address the knowledge I gained, the objectives I met through coursework, and the ways those skills apply in a professional environment. They connect classroom learning to workplace behaviors an employer could expect from me, including leading teams, evaluating problems, writing clearly, developing employees, and supporting organizational goals.

MGMT101: Principles of Supervision

Principles of Supervision strengthened my understanding of what effective supervision looks like beyond rank, title, or position. Supervising people requires clear expectations, sound judgment, accountability, and a steady approach to developing others. Robbins and Coulter (2021) describe management as a process that includes planning, organizing, leading, and controlling. That framework helped me connect the daily responsibilities of a supervisor to the larger purpose of aligning team performance with organizational goals.

A central takeaway was understanding the supervisor's role as the link between leadership intent and employee performance. Course activities required me to consider how supervisors communicate priorities, establish standards, delegate responsibilities, and follow up on work without micromanaging every detail. They also reinforced the importance of explaining the reason behind a task rather than only directing someone to complete it. In my current position, I often receive broad guidance that must be translated into clear direction for instructors, students, and staff. That process requires identifying the desired outcome, assigning responsibilities, setting timelines, and confirming that everyone understands the standard. These skills matter in any workplace because employees perform more effectively when they understand the purpose, expectations, and importance of their work.

Goal setting and problem-solving were other important parts of the course. Daft (2022) explains that managers help organizations achieve goals by coordinating resources and guiding people toward desired outcomes. The coursework emphasized that useful goals must be specific, measurable, realistic, and connected to organizational priorities. I applied that concept by examining how supervisors establish deadlines, monitor progress, and adjust plans when resources or circumstances change. In practice, that includes preparing instructors, managing schedules, supporting evaluations, and ensuring training requirements are completed on time. When an issue arises, I must determine whether the problem stems from unclear guidance, limited resources, competing demands, or an individual performance concern. That distinction helps me address the actual cause rather than react only to the visible symptom. Clear goals reduce guesswork, support accountability, and allow the team to focus its effort where it matters most.

Conflict management helped me better understand how supervisors protect morale and productivity. Conflict is not always a sign that something is broken, but unresolved issues can distract the team and erode trust. Through course scenarios and discussions, I examined how leaders gather facts, listen to each person involved, separate assumptions from evidence, and keep the conversation focused on standards rather than personalities. The course also highlighted the importance of addressing disagreements early, before frustration begins to affect communication or performance. That lesson

applies when working through communication gaps, competing priorities, personality differences, or performance concerns. A supervisor must remain neutral, clarify expectations, identify an appropriate resolution, and follow up to ensure the issue does not resurface.

Employee development was the most useful aspect of the workforce connection. Supervisors are responsible for more than correcting mistakes. They coach, mentor, document performance, recognize strengths, and help employees improve. The course showed that development works best when feedback is timely, specific, and tied to observable behavior. General comments such as “do better” provide little direction, while clear feedback helps an employee understand what occurred, why it mattered, and what should change. This course gave academic structure to leadership skills I use when preparing personnel for greater responsibility, helping instructors refine their delivery, and building confidence across the team. It also reinforced that accountability and development should work together. Employees need honest feedback, but they also need support, resources, and an opportunity to improve.

MGMT101 demonstrates my understanding of supervision as a balance among people, processes, and performance. The course helped me connect daily leadership actions to broader workplace expectations, especially in areas such as communication, delegation, feedback, accountability, conflict resolution, team development, and goal alignment. These skills will support future roles in operations, compliance, and program analysis, where success depends on both managing requirements and helping people perform at a high level.

BUSN410: Critical Thinking Strategies for Business Decisions

Critical Thinking Strategies for Business Decisions was one of the most valuable courses for my professional growth because it strengthened my ability to evaluate problems, question assumptions, and make well-supported recommendations. Leaders often feel pressure to react quickly when something appears wrong, but speed does not always equal quality. Browne and Keeley (2023) emphasize the importance of asking strong questions before accepting a conclusion. That approach helped me slow down, examine the information in front of me, and avoid treating the first explanation as the correct one.

It also reinforced that a sound decision depends on the quality of the questions asked before action is taken.

One of the key skills I developed was defining the problem before selecting a solution. Discussions and assignments required me to separate symptoms from root causes before deciding what action made sense. A missed deadline may appear to be poor individual performance, but the real issue could be unclear guidance, limited resources, competing requirements, or a communication breakdown. Identifying the root cause requires more than noticing what went wrong. It involves reviewing the available facts, recognizing patterns, considering the perspectives of those involved, and distinguishing verified information from assumptions. In my current role, this process helps me avoid knee-jerk reactions and respond to the actual issue rather than correcting only the visible symptoms.

Evaluating information was another essential part of the course. Not every source, opinion, or data point should carry the same weight. Coursework required me to consider whether information was reliable, relevant, complete, current, and evidence-based before using it to justify a decision. I learned to question where the information came from, whether important details were missing, and whether the evidence truly supported the conclusion being presented. This process also involved distinguishing facts from opinions and recognizing when a recommendation relied more on personal preference than objective information. These skills connect directly to future roles in compliance, inspections, and program analysis, where findings must be traceable to evidence, and recommendations must withstand review.

The course pushed me to recognize bias and assumptions in decision-making. Experience is valuable, but it can create blind spots when leaders rely too heavily on what has worked before or search only for evidence that supports their initial view. Through coursework, I became more deliberate about considering alternative explanations, seeking different perspectives, and asking whether my first reaction was supported by facts. This habit is useful when reviewing curriculum changes, instructor development, scheduling issues, and performance concerns. It allows me to challenge my own thinking before presenting a recommendation that may affect other people or organizational processes. Decision-making requires thinking beyond the immediate fix. Robbins and Coulter (2021) note that managers make

decisions while considering organizational goals, constraints, and consequences. Course assignments encouraged me to evaluate how stakeholders, risk, available resources, implementation requirements, and second-order effects influence the quality of a recommendation. A proposed solution may appear effective but still create new problems if it requires resources the organization lacks, disrupts another process, or affects employees differently than expected. For example, a change to curriculum or evaluation procedures may improve consistency but also require instructor retraining, schedule adjustments, and additional oversight. Considering those effects helps leaders develop recommendations that are practical, sustainable, and aligned with organizational priorities.

BUSN410 strengthened the type of judgment employers need in roles involving analysis, compliance, inspections, and program review. The course demonstrates my ability to define problems, evaluate evidence, challenge assumptions, consider consequences, and make practical recommendations based on more than surface-level information. These skills will help me review programs objectively, communicate findings clearly, and recommend improvements that address both immediate concerns and long-term organizational needs.

ENGL226: Effective Business Communication

Effective Business Communication strengthened one of the most important skills I use in a professional setting. Communication affects how expectations are understood, how decisions are carried out, and how credibility is built. Bovée and Thill (2024) explain that effective business messages depend on purpose, audience awareness, clarity, and organization. That directly connects to my current work because a message lacking structure or purpose can create confusion, slow down decision-making, or cause people to miss important information.

Audience awareness became one of the most practical skills I strengthened in the course. Assignments gave me practice shaping messages around the audience, the information they needed, and the action they were expected to take. A message to senior leadership should be concise and decision-focused, while communication with staff may require more context, background, and direction. In my current position, I regularly communicate with different audiences, so I cannot rely on a one-size-fits-all

approach. The course also emphasized choosing a communication method that fits the message's purpose and complexity. Some situations can be handled through a brief email, while others require a formal memorandum, report, or face-to-face discussion followed by written documentation. Selecting the appropriate format helps prevent misunderstandings and ensures the message receives the level of attention it requires.

Organization was another area of growth. Strong workplace writing should make the purpose clear early, provide enough detail to support understanding, and identify the required action. I applied this through assignments focused on business messages and professional correspondence. That skill carries over to emails, evaluations, recommendations, counseling documents, and staff communication. Clear writing saves time and helps people act without having to chase down missing context.

Professional tone became a practical takeaway rather than simply a writing rule. Leaders often need to be direct, but their communication should remain respectful and controlled because tone can determine whether a message encourages cooperation or creates defensiveness. The course helped me refine how I address concerns, provide direction, and communicate expectations while maintaining professionalism. Revising and proofreading became an important part of that process because they allowed me to review messages from the reader's perspective, remove unnecessary wording, confirm that the requested action was clear, and ensure the tone matched the purpose. That extra review is especially important when communicating policy changes, performance concerns, or recommendations that may influence a decision.

Workplace writing should support action, not just sound polished. I met this objective by preparing communications that helped readers understand, respond, decide, or act. That skill is especially important for future roles in operations, compliance, policy review, or program analysis, where written findings and recommendations must be easy to follow. In compliance or program analysis work, a strong recommendation must explain the issue, connect the evidence to the conclusion, and identify a realistic course of action. ENGL226 supports one of the most transferable skills I can bring to a civilian

workplace: clear, professional communication. The course strengthened my ability to write with purpose, organize information for readers, and produce messages that clarify expectations and prompt action.

HRMT407: Human Resource Management

Human Resource Management helped me view people management from a broader organizational perspective. Leadership experience taught me the importance of developing people, setting expectations, and holding standards. This course connected those responsibilities to human resource functions such as staffing, training, performance management, workplace fairness, and retention. Noe (2023) explains that employee development should improve both individual capability and organizational performance. That idea closely aligns with the work I do in developing instructors and supporting professional growth.

A stronger understanding of human resource practices helped me see how staffing, training, evaluation, and retention directly support organizational goals. Coursework connected HR concepts to practical workplace situations where the right person, with the right preparation, can improve team effectiveness. People are not separate from the mission. The way an organization selects, trains, evaluates, and retains employees directly affects performance and credibility.

Staffing and placement helped me think more carefully about how organizations match people to responsibilities. Filling a vacancy is not the same as placing the right person in the right role. Leaders must consider experience, potential, strengths, limitations, and mission needs. In my current work, assigning responsibilities to instructors or staff requires that same judgment. Someone may be capable of a task but still need coaching, oversight, or time to build confidence.

Training and development were especially relevant to my current role. I met this objective by examining how structured preparation, feedback, and follow-through improve performance. Training should build capability rather than serve as a check-the-box requirement. When development is treated seriously, it improves confidence, consistency, and long-term team readiness.

Performance management tied the course directly to workforce application. Aguinis (2023) explains that performance management is a continuous process that connects employee performance with

organizational goals. That concept applies to instructor certifications, student performance, counseling, and daily mentorship. Fair evaluations, documentation, and timely feedback help people understand where they stand and how to improve. HRMT407 reinforced my belief that people are not just resources on a spreadsheet. They are the driving force behind organizational performance, and leaders need to manage them with fairness, structure, and accountability.

Conclusion

The four selected courses show how my business education supports my current responsibilities and future career objectives. MGMT101 strengthened my understanding of supervision, employee development, and performance expectations. BUSN410 improved the way I define problems, evaluate information, and make sound recommendations. ENGL226 sharpened my ability to communicate with purpose, audience awareness, and professional tone. HRMT407 expanded my understanding of staffing, training, performance management, and workplace fairness.

These courses help translate my military experience into business concepts that employers can recognize. Rather than viewing each course as a separate area of study, I see them as connected parts of effective organizational performance. Strong supervision supports people, critical thinking improves decisions, clear communication turns those decisions into action, and sound human resource practices help sustain performance over time. Together, these skills prepare me to contribute in roles involving operations, compliance, inspections, program analysis, policy review, and process improvement while supporting both employee development and organizational goals.

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